Los Angeles Times

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MATTHIEU RONDEL AFP/Getty Images

MORE PROTESTS ROIL FRANCE

Police officers gather on Faubourg du Temple street as clashes erupted at Place de la Republique in Paris on Sunday. About 2,400 people were arrested as weekend rallies turned to rioting and looting. **WORLD, A2**

L.A. transit woes ignite debate in mayor's race

Delayed LAX people mover tops the list of transportation challenges facing city.

BY COLLEEN SHALBY

There are myriad public transportation challenges for the next Los Angeles mayor, but perhaps none is more visible than the long-awaited Skylink people mover train at Los Angeles International Airport.

The 2.25-mile train, designed to whisk people from airline terminals to ground transportation, is years behind schedule and more than $1 billion over its original construction budget — bogged down by technical issues and a court battle between the contractor and city airport officials.

And now it has become one of the more contentious issues in the mayoral race between incumbent Karen Bass and challenger Nithya Raman.

Raman says Bass and the the city's board of airport commissioners, which the mayor appoints, haven't done enough to keep costs in check and to ensure construction deadlines are met.

"Over two years ago, when the project was already a year behind schedule, Mayor Bass's airport commissioners cut a $550-million check in order to cover project cost overruns and supposedly to secure a start service in January of this year, 2026," Raman said in a statement to The Times. "That date came and went and she hasn't said anything about how she'll get the project on track."

Bass said that the project and its problems began before she took office and that "we pushed for a settlement so there would be a firm finish line."

"I expect LAWA [Los Angeles World Airports] and the contractor to finish this job and get riders on board," Bass said in a statement to The Times.

The Skylink train is just one of many transit challenges Los Angeles' next leader will face, as voter-approved street improvements and road safety initiatives lag. But it has become one of the more significant given

[See **Transit,** A5]



Photographs by ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

MAYOR Karen Bass and challenger Nithya Raman often align on transit, but they diverge on priorities.

A FUROR OVER 'INSANE' DWP BILLS

Angelenos are hit by sticker shock. Utility blames higher A/C use, not rate increases.

BY BLANCA BEGERT

Social media and online forums are aflame over higher than usual Los Angeles Department of Water and Power bills, with some customers noting recent charges hundreds of dollars over what they paid in previous billing cycles and years.

Residents are posting bills they call "outrageous," "insane" and "extremely crazy" as charges for summer use continue to hit mailboxes. Canter's Deli made headlines when its owners received a $35,700 bill, up almost $11,000 from four months earlier.

Recent increases in sewer and trash fees, plus steadily rising water rates and higher summer water use are partly to blame. But Angelenos' ire has been especially directed at electricity bills as the extra A/C needed during triple-digit heat waves landed people in the utility's higher-cost tiers, which also have been rising.

More than 24,000 people have signed a petition calling for the city to investigate the bills and adjust the tiers. It was started by a San Fernando Valley man who received a $2,115 electric bill for his 2,500-square-foot home that he said he kept at 74 degrees between the months of August and September.

Electric bill sticker shock is common for customers of investor-owned utilities, but less so for municipally owned utilities such as DWP.

Denise Grab, clean-energy project director at UCLA's Emmett Institute on Climate Change and the Environment, said that over the last three years, Southern California Edison's rate for the typical household using 500 kWh per month has risen about 4% while DWP's has gone up 45%. But Edison still charges about 20% more than DWP.

"They're closer than they were last year," when she published a report comparing the two utilities, Grab said. She also expects Edison rates to rise further when wildfire liability from the Eaton fire hits.

DWP says its recent high bills are driven by spiking power use during the record-breaking summer heat, especially for air conditioning, not by rate increases.

Most of its residential customers are in a three-tier

[See **Electricity,** A8]

Republican sees a path back to power in state

BY DAKOTA SMITH

ROSEVILLE, Calif. — San Diego County Republican Carl DeMaio had a warning for conservatives at a get-out-the-vote rally this month in Placer County.

"You are doomed," DeMaio said, crooning the phrase like a foghorn. The audience chuckled.

"Doomed" is DeMaio's description for races that lack a conservative candidate. Skip voting in those, he told the crowd, briskly walking them through the Nov. 3 ballot.

Microphone in hand, the freshman state legislator paced the floor, threw up his hands and scowled as he declared California a "communist state," the progressive Bay Area "the gates of hell" and Hillary Clinton "the wicked witch."

Urging volunteers to door-knock at Republican households, he instructed them to ignore Democratic homes.

"I don't need to remind them there's an election going on," he said.

DeMaio, 52, is emerging as a prominent voice for California Republicans, promising a path back to power and delighting audiences with his sharp takedowns of Democrats. His vehicle this election is Proposition 39 — he is co-author of the ballot measure — which would require Californians to provide ID when voting, an initiative backed by millions of dollars from conservatives and condemned by the state's Democratic leaders and voting rights experts.

On his YouTube channel, he regularly skewers Gov. Gavin Newsom, the Sacramento "swamp" and the media with shows titled, "Thinking of California? 3 Reasons Not to!" and "Socialism on the CA Ballot in 2026!"

His advocacy group, Reform California, supports

[See **DeMaio,** A8]

Prop. 45 fight focuses on data centers

Two sides disagree on whether the initiative would make it easier to build the facilities.

BY LILA SEIDMAN

When a county judge put the brakes on what would be the largest data center in California, ruling the whole project needed extensive environmental review, Kristian Salgado was relieved.

The community organizer lives in Imperial County, where the nearly 1-million-square-foot facility was proposed. The rural county near the Mexico border struggles with air pollution and has one of the state's highest rates of asthma hospitalization for kids, according to the National Institute of Environmental Health Sciences. One of Salgado's nephews lives right next to the site and struggles with the respiratory disease.

"It just seemed very unusual that a project of this scale, with that many backup generators, could be permitted without requiring any further [analysis] of what that would mean for residents," she said.

Now, Salgado and others who share her concern believe Proposition 45 on the November ballot could roll back their wins. The initiative would change the California Environmental Quality Act, a law intended to inform decision makers and the public about a project's possible environmental impacts and mitigate them to the extent possible.

Supporters say Proposition 45 will speed up environmental review for essential housing, transportation, water, health, education and other projects, cutting costly delays and passing the savings on to consumers.

Opponents say it not only weakens environmental protections for many developments but also will cover potentially polluting ones, including data centers.

The Yes on 45 campaign rejects the data center claim, but independent legal experts are divided.

At the heart of the debate is the definition of one of the categories covered by Proposition 45: "broadband internet access projects" or "mass-market retail service

[See **Environment,** A5]

'No trail on my ancestor's bones'

A scenic path promises economic boost. Tribes see it as betrayal.



ANDREW CULLEN For The Times

THE HUMBOLDT BAY Trail could become part of the new trail.

BY LILA SEIDMAN

The murky, magnificent Eel River was once a highway for the Wailaki people, who navigated by canoe and hauled goods between villages in cone-shaped baskets. But the tribe was forced out during the Gold Rush and, decades later, a railroad was built along the river in this verdant stretch of Humboldt County.

Perry Lincoln, whose grandmother came from one of those villages, today sees another affront: the Great Redwood Trail, a 307-mile path planned along the remnants of the long-gone railroad that cuts through his ancestral land.

When they first learned of the project a few years ago, he says, some people, both Native and non-Native, thought: "But wait a minute, this is

[See **Trail,** A6]

Disney's big bid to hold fans' attention

The company ramps up its investment in content creators, seen as trusted sources.

BY CERYS DAVIES AND SAMANTHA MASUNAGA

Beneath the watchful eyes of Snow White's Seven Dwarfs that hold up the Walt Disney Co. corporate offices in Burbank, performers from the Broadway production of "Aladdin" were belting the familiar notes of "A Whole New World" to a sea of raised phones and cameras.

A rapt audience of nearly 70 content creators was filming every moment of the performance for their followers. They were gathered on the studio lot last month as part of Disney's Somos Magic Summit, a three-day event involving a series of panels and presentations at the company's corporate headquarters and excursion to the Disneyland Resort theme parks. The goal: to deepen the relationship between the entertainment giant and these key Latino internet personalities.

"You grow up watching Disney on TV and playing with Disney toys, and then to see them wanting to work with you, it's like, OK, like, what is going on right now?" said Natalie Aguilar, a 24-year-old San Diego-based influencer known for making feel-good content online with her family.

As social media continue to act as a cultural megaphone, content creators are now widely seen as an essential part of marketing for companies of all kinds, in-

[See **Disney,** A10]

Canada military base fire kills 4
The blaze in Alberta also leaves 39 people hospitalized, 19 in critical condition, officials say. **WORLD, A2**

Dissecting the wealth tax fight
Billionaires' attack on Prop. 40 is based on largely imaginary outcomes, Michael Hiltzik writes. **BUSINESS, A10**

New-look Lakers tout bona fides
Coach JJ Redick and superstar Luka Doncic believe the team can compete in the stacked West. **SPORTS, D6**

Weather
Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 85/63. **B6**

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